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Imamate Seven Days**

**on the slogan
Prophethood and Imamate:
Two Single-Rooted Palm Trees beyond Chasm**

**entitled
Imamate: Nation System**

Eighth Part

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“First International Imamate Seven Days” as a conference heaves into view, readership, academics and audiences to disseminate the knowledge lights of the golden family, the golden mind that ploughs the first pathway of faith and dignity in the world. On July 7 2023 a constellation of researchers worldwide showed their papers on a prismatic topic “Prophethood and Imamate: Two Single-Rooted Palm Trees beyond Chasm” to explicate certain sermons, narrative and interdisciplinary studies on Ahlalbayt in two main sessions: morning and evening events. The scientific committee of the conference accepted only 16 papers as innovative in the field and the other ones met with unanimous rejection.

As planned and programmed , the seven-day stay bore fruit to have a plethora of academic discussion on the heritage of Ahlalbayt , peace be upon them, and the strategies to have their ethics, doctrines and literature promulgated throughout the world . It is all agreed that the modern age is the age of great changes and man has to find a harbour in a storm to shield his life, his mind, his family and his identity. In doing so, a group of international researchers attended an evening seminar to find common ground to be in the “editorial board” of “Qerba Journal”. Most updated topics were tackled to take priority in the future issues of the journal.

In the long term , we , the Alkafeel Centre for translation as a part of the Intellectual and Scientific Society of Al-`Ameed , exert ourselves more and more to bring all the academic missions of the Holy Al-`Abbas Shrine into effect and reality , which falls within the remit of human prosperity , peace , coexistence and mercy .



Anti-Slavery Quest in The Manners of Imam Ali bin Al Hussein

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Abstract

Despite the abundant writings about slave abolition and Islam, little researches have touched on Ahl al-Bayt's role in this era. Particularly, a serious gap of knowledge exists in discussing their role in developing human rights in the Islamic context. Yet, their morals and manners were a vital appeal to freedom and social justice that was defined later on with more details in subsequent treaties. This paper traces the fundamental role played by Imam Ali bin Al Hussein bin Ali (PBUT) in the anti-slavery appeal, and slave abolition. His life and behavior can be considered as an approach to Islamic law, and epistemology of Islamic divinities for human rights. The paper openly presents the principles of Ali bin Al-Hussein's time, policy, and spirituality. He declined the appropriation of man by establishing a deep system of anti-slavery and abolitionism, and putting its roots by providing protection, life necessities, and freedom for the slaves in his time.

Keywords: Islam, Prophet Mohamed, Ali bin Al Hussein, slavery, slave abolition.

تقويض نظام الرق في فكر الامام علي بن الحسين عليه السلام

م. رنا جابر عبيد الحميدي

المديرية العامة لتربية القادسية

الملخص

المقصود بالرق أو العبودية ملكية الانسان لإنسان آخر، والتصرف به كملك مطلق. وقد عُرِفَت هذه الظاهرة منذ عصور سحيقة، وتجدرت في مختلف المجتمعات على اختلاف درجة تحضرها. وعندما جاء الإسلام وهو دين الحرية والعدالة والمساواة، وجد امامه تركة جاهلية ثقيلة تستعبد الانسان وتستبيح كرامته فكانت قضية العبودية من القضايا الكبرى التي حاربها: إذ اخذ على عاتقه تحرير الانسان من كل أنواع الاستعباد، وسعى الى بناء انسان حر كريم لا يدين بخضوع الا لخالقه.

وعلى الرغم من كثرة الدراسات حول مواقف الإسلام الحازمة منقضية الرق، والطرق التي اتبعتها لتجفيف منابعه الا ان هناك قلة واضحة في الدراسات التي تعرض لموقف أهل البيت (عليهم السلام) في هذه القضية، ودورهم الريادي في مناهضتها: فهم القرآن الناطق، والتجسيد العملي لمبادئ الإسلام العظيمة، وذرية القائل «أما اخ لك في الدين، او نظير لك في الخلق».

وقد اختارت هذه الورقة البحثية موقف الامام زين العابدين (عليه السلام) من قضية الرق والعبودية: وذلك لخصوصية المرحلة التي عاصرها الامام فهي مرحلة حساسة جداً وعلامة مظلمة في تاريخ الامة فيما يتعلق بموضوع

الرقيق: إذ بلغت النزعة العنصرية والعرقية في عصره ذروتها: وذلك حين استولى على مقاليد السلطة حكام مثّلوا أنموذجا مقبّيا للعنجهية الجاهلية التي تمتهن الإنسان، وتعبث بكرامته.

لقد كان الامام زين العابدين عليه السلام شخصية فاعلة ومؤثرة في مجتمعه. ناهض نظام الرق، وحارب الفكر الاستعلائي الذي يمتهن الإنسان أيا كان عرقه أو دينه، ونادى بمبادئ الإسلام التي حاول الامويون طمسها والعودة الى نزعات الجاهلية الأولى فكان عليه السلام في حياته وسلوكه مؤسسا لنظام عميق يناهض العبودية، ويسعى الى إلغائها وهذا ما ستعرضه هذه الورقة البحثية.

الكلمات المفتاحية: الإسلام، النبي محمد، علي بن الحسين، الرق، إلغاء العبودية.



The right of your servant upon you is your blessing; You must know that God has made you his protector, guard, helper, and stronghold. God makes him as a means and a reason for you to separate you from hell.(Ali bin Al-Hussein, The Letter of Rights, the right of slaves)

Introduction: Ali bin Al Hussein and his time

It was narrated by Jabir bin Abdullah Al-Ansari that he said: I was sitting near the Prophet Mohammed (PBUH) and he was carrying Al Hussein and playing with him. The Prophet said “O Jabir, a son will be born to him, whose name is Ali. On the Day of Resurrection, a herald will call: “where is ‘the master of worshipers.’ Then, Ali bin Al-Hussein will stand up. If you see him, O Jabir, tell him my greetings.”¹ Ali bin Al Hussein is the best comprehensive repository of divine knowledge in all branches: belief, law, morals, and mysticism. He is the perfect model of the Islamic personality in its appointments, way of life, and its Sunnah. He is the representative of the Qur’an, and the living interpreter of its verses. His presence - alive – is essential to Islam and more effective for Muslims within the huge vacuum and deadly drought in that Islamic society. He terrorizes the enemies of Islam more than a thousand of swords, and Islam is only preserved by the survival of his ideas and values. All Muslims of his time recognized him as the most knowledgeable, and pious of his time. Imam Malik said: “Ali bin Al Hussein was named as Zayn al-Abidin because of his great worship. He is the prostrated, and the master of the worshipper.” Al-Shafi also considered him to be: “the wisest of the people of Madinah.” These facts were also acknowledged by the Umayyad rulers of his time, despite their enmity and rivalry. Abd al-Malik bin Marwan said to him: “You have been given knowledge, religion, and piety that no one has

been given before you, except those of your predecessors.” Besides, Omar bin Abdulaziz described him as “the light of the world and the beauty of Islam.”²

According to Al-Asbah by Sheikh al-Tusi and Al-Iqbal by Ibn Tawus, the most authentic narrations, he was born in 38 AH, and he was twenty-three years old on the day of the Battle of Karbala. He remained after his father for thirty-four years. History did not shed sufficient light on his life before the war of Al-Taff, but they shed more light on his life after the War. Actually, the nation in his time was without cultural immunity and this can be attributed to the political hostility against the Prophet’s family, (PBUT), since they represent the pure sources of cultural resistance for the Islamic nation. Nations used to maintain their own culture from being lost or their heritage being plundered. Yet, the ruling policies made the greatest efforts to be diminished. Among that ruling policies were the efforts of the Umayyads. Historians asserted that the Umayyads blackened history with their heinous deeds, for which humanity is infatuated. They cut off people’s heads, and they walked around the country with it. Sheikh Ali al-Kurani said that one of the German specialists stated that: (We must erect a golden statue of Muawiyah bin Abi Sufyan in a square in our capital, Berlin! Because he is the one who transformed the Islamic system of government from its democratic basis into fanaticism. Without that, Islam would have spread to the whole world, and therefore we Germans and all the peoples of Europe would have been Arab Muslims) Therefore, the Western world considers Muawiya to be the best in the West.³

Despite the Umayyads’ attempts to obliterate and bury the historical relics of Imam Ali bin Al Hussein, we have received from his acquaintance, etiquette, morals, and knowledge of



what would be a beacon and a torch that guide the nation. When you dive into the life of Imam Ali bin Al Hussein and look at his behavior and actions, you will be certain that this Imam was acting on various roles. In his morals, you find the political as well as social role. For example, al-Zuhri, one of his contemporaries, narrates: one night, I was walking, and I found Imam Zain al-Abidin, (PBUH), masked, and he was carrying luggage on his back. I asked him and he told me that he was travelling, but after a period of one or two nights, I saw him in the city. I told him, sir, I did not see any trace of that journey. He said, "This is the journey of the afterlife. I carry luggage to the hungry stomachs, to the thirsty livers, and the fearful souls." It was food that he carried to the poor, the chaste, who were not reached by their descendants. Rather, they abstained from telling people about their poverty. In this manner, the Imam represented the political role because he was resisting a politics of the Umayyads in his time. Also, Imam has practiced the social role that aims to draw the most beautiful pictures of solidarity among people, and he has exercised his educational role.⁴

In his Ahl al-Bayt, Sayyid Muhammad Baqir al-Sadr mentioned that during the era of Imam, there were multiple real crises: political, economic, social, and intellectual crises, which is the most serious one. This crisis arose for two reasons: The first is the openness to the non-Islamic civilizations that have intellectual systems, vocabularies, teachings and traditions that differ from what exists in Islamic civilization. When the civilization of a particular nation opens up in all its dimensions, it will undoubtedly affect the intellectual system of the other nation. Deviant ideas have spread among Muslims, such as the idea of reparation and delegation, the idea of fatalism, and other ancient Greek ideas.⁵

The second reason for this intellectual crisis is the deceiving process carried out by the authorities at the time, which is called brainwashing. Muawiyah occupied those who were among his entourage with making a history that he manipulated as he wanted. In *Al Sahih in al-Sirah*, Sayyid Jaafar Mortada al-Amili argues that the Levantines thought that the relatives of the Prophet and his household were the family of Abu Sufyan, Muawiyah and Yazid bin Muawiyah.⁶ Also, in *Condolences, Elegies and Commandments*, Muhammad bin Yazid al-Mubarrad, mentions that Muawiyah left three commandments to his son Yazid. A will related to the people of Al Madinah, a will related to the people of Iraq, and a will related to the people of the Levant. In the will that is related to the Levantines, he said, “You should know that the people of Levant are your inner circle. Depend on them, and do not depend on another faction or another country in all your wars. As soon as the war ends, you have to return them immediately to the Levant, and do not let them mix with others, so that they do not discover a culture that clashes with the culture that they have,” which is Muawiyah’s policy of brainwashing.⁷

In the midst of these circumstances, how was the Imam able to change these people? The process of changing sometimes tends towards changing the superstructures as well as the original systems. Imam Zayn al-Abidin realized that by changing the superstructures, this society would inevitably collapse, even if he became a ruler. It is the society that kills Al-Hussein Bin Ali, who is the master of the youth of Paradise, and before that revolts against the Commander of the Faithful, Ali Bin Abi Talib, who is the master of the guardians, the brother of the Messenger of God, and guardian of this society. Indeed, the Umayyad society collapsed overwhelmingly, and even the members of



the Umayyad family turned against their affairs.⁸ Muawiyah bin Yazid bin Muawiyah II disavows the Umayyads and their actions. He said in the pulpit that my father and grandfather were usurpers of the caliphate, and the next person to it, was Ali bin Al-Hussein Al-Sajjad. That is why, the Imam aimed at changing the successive societies that have reached our time. He wanted to change the coming generations, establishing an intellectually correct minds based on high morals, correct Quranic education, and the knowledge of Ahl al-Bayt, (PBUT). Historians have stated that "Ali bin Al Hussein had disciples, just as Jesus, (PBUH), had disciples."⁹

Imam Ali bin Al Hussein emphasizes the necessity of moral reconstruction for the nation. That is why the Imam writes a huge legacy of morals and supplications in an endless generosity of morals. The legacy is The Letter of Rights. It can be considered as the greatest document of human rights. Ali bin Al Hussein precedes all the international declarations, human rights documents, and conferences that request man to respect his equivalent man and to recognize his right to a free and dignified life. The Imam consolidates these principles through an integrated human rights theory, and human rights treatise that can rightfully be considered as a preamble to all human rights documents in the world, even if it came before more than a thousand year. Among the rights was the right of the slaves over their masters. With this methodology, the Imam was able to bring people to religion. Specifically, Imam Ali bin Al-Hussein (PBUH) dealt humanely with the slaves. He made a great effort to elevate them scientifically, religiously, and morally. Many of them became active and influential members in the Islamic community, despite the inferior social view of slaves in that period. We can say that

Imam Ali bin Al-Hussein aims to educate society to respect human rights and preserve its dignity through respecting the principles of pure Islam and rejecting the ideas of the Umayyad authorities that call for racism in treatment.

Islam and slave abolition

Slavery is a person's possession of another human being, and disposing him as an absolute monarch. Peoples and nations have long known slavery. It was experienced before and after Islam. This phenomenon has been known and entrenched since ancient times in various societies of all levels of civilization. When Islam came, it found a substantial legacy that enslaves man and violates his self-esteem. Slavery was deeply rooted in Arabian society and casually accepted, not as a vice, but a device of honor, pride and status. Humanity did not get rid of it lawfully and officially except in the twentieth century. Islam encourages slave abolition, and considers it as one of the best acts to worship God. Islam closes many of the sources and techniques that led to enslavement. The Quran contains a number of verses that aim to control slavery and mitigate its negative impacts. It calls for the manumission of slaves, and prescribes kindness towards slaves. They are considered morally equal to free persons. However, they have a lower legal standing. All Quranic rules on slaves are emancipatory in that they improve the rights of slaves compared to what was already practiced in the 7th century. Many Muslims have interpreted the Quran as gradually phasing out slavery.¹⁰

In his farewell sermon, The Holy Prophet, (PBUH), emphasizes: "An Arab has no superiority over a non-Arab, nor does a non-Arab have any superiority over an Arab; A white person has no superiority over the black person, nor does a black have any superiority over whites, except by piety and good actions."



Based on this fundamental teaching, Islam approaches this problem, which wasn't depend on race or ethnicities. Deep considerations and wise steps were taken almost 1,500 years ago when slavery was not only accepted but was glorified and lauded.¹¹

Within 23 years of his prophethood, the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) turned the stream of this wicked crime against humanity and ended slavery in an authentic manner. He called his black freed slave as "master" and married the divorced wife of his freed slave. Any slave that came into his possession, he freed immediately while upholding their rights. He urged all Muslims to do the same. It is a severe rational dishonesty to say that the Prophet Muhammad traded or promoted slavery, yet, he was the one man who effectively abolished slavery. Islam also ensured that even after the emancipation of slaves, they were not left without support and helpers. The Holy Prophet established a bond of brotherhood between the freed slaves and their former masters. They were to be called each other's maula – helper or friend. This was to ensure that they would stand by each other in times of prerequisite. They were given the right to inherit each other if one died and did not leave an heir behind.¹²

Correspondingly, in order to abolish slavery, Muslims married slaves. Also, these freed slaves were blessed with a household and marital rights; their inferiority was practically put to an end through their new freedom. The Prophet appointed Zaid bin Haritha, a freed slave of him and his son, Usama duties overseeing very important military missions, while many of his most well-known and high-placed Companions served under them. The Prophet stood within the crowd of his Companions, saying: "Bear witness that this Zaid is my son. He inherits me and I inherit him." His name among Muslims remained Zaid bin Muham-

mad until the Holy Qur'an abolished the tradition of adoption. The Prophet says: "By God, just as Zaid was fit for leadership and was one of those whom I most loved and trusted, similarly, his son Usama is fit for leadership and is one of the most beloved and trusted men to me."¹³

The Prophet's family, the Imams of Ahl al-Bayt, and Companions also adopted these drills with so much pride that not only did they free their own slaves but also purchased slaves with non-Muslim masters, only to free them out of goodwill. "The freeing of slaves was regarded as the high-mountain road that led to heights of divine nearness" (Al-Balad, 11-13). Ahl al-Bayt (PBUT) used to buy large numbers of slaves as servants in order to liberate them. However, they would remain for a period of time under the guidance of infallibility and the refinement of their morals and beliefs, and then they would be freed. Perhaps we find in the work of Imam Ali bin Al Hussein a complete picture of this trend. He used to buy slaves and raise them during a whole year. Historians have described us the way Imam Ali bin Al Hussein (PBUH) dealt with slaves and his mercy, pardon, benevolence, forgiveness, humility, and tolerance towards them. Imam (PBUH) cared a lot about the issue of raising slaves on religious and moral values, teaching them the most important issues and rulings of Islam, and then freeing them. This matter prompted these slaves to pledge allegiance to the Imam (PBUH), to remain faithful to the doctrinal line to Ahl al-Bayt (PBUT), and to have loyalty and love for the Imam (PBUH). After finishing the moral training session for a whole year, the Imam sets them free.¹⁴

Ali bin Al Hussein's policy with slaves

In Ibn Al-Atheer's Al-Kamil in History, it was stated that during the era of Imam Ali bin Al Hussein (PBUH), slaves spread in abun-



dance in society, as a result of the entry of Muslims into other countries, and the expansion of the geographical area. Imam Ali bin Al Hussein was a contemporary of the rule of Abd al-Malik bin Marwan and his son Al-Walid bin Abd Al-Malik. After eliminating the Zubayrid movement in the Hijaz and Iraq, Abd al-Malik headed towards expanding the Islamic area, especially in Africa. He was able to seize countless numbers of slaves as well as gold and wealth. Also, in Andalusia, Tariq bin Ziyad and Musa bin Al Naseer achieved the Arab conquest of Andalusia, which is also known as the Islamic conquest of Spain. This wealth, by its nature, raises the standard of living of the community, especially that of prestige and social symbols in the nation. Captivity, money and slaves were the sources of income and enrichment for Muslims. For example, the rulers used to pay them as gifts and endowments to fulfill their needs. Likewise, the Muslims gained more than 60,000 slaves from this country. All of those turned into loyalists within the nation. Ibn al-Atheer states that: "the number reached sixty-five thousand heads of captivity. No one ever mentioned having heard of a curse greater than this."¹⁵

The tribal spirit, nationalism, and pre-Islamic customs had a negative impact on dealing with slaves. However, Ali bin Al Hussein (PBUH) has transcended all those Arab customs and traditions inherited from the pre-Islamic times, and married a slave woman, despite his high position, deep scientific status, and authentic Arab lineage. He wanted to prove the legal rulings, the major purposes of Islam, and get rid of the erroneous class and tribal spirit. The Umayyads tried to undermine the high status of Imam Ali Bin Al Hussein (PBUH), belittling his position because of his marriage to his slave. The spies of Abd al-Malik bin Marwan, who were broadcast by the governor of Medina to moni-

tor the leaders of the nation and its symbols, headed by Imam Ali bin Al-Hussein (PBUH), noticed that Imam had freed his slave and married her. Thus, Abd al-Malik wrote to Ali bin Al-Hussein (PBUH): "I have been informed that you have married your mistress, and I knew that among the Quraysh there were those who were glorified by him in marriage and who were qualified to bear children. You did not know the value of yourself or your children." So, Ali bin Al-Hussein (PBUH) wrote to him: "I have heard your letter criticizing me for marrying my slave, and claiming that there was among the women of Quraysh those whom I glorified in marriage and preferred in childbirth..... Rather, it was my slave whom I liberated, as God wanted me to seek his reward. In Islam, God has raised the despicable, and completed the lack. It is the most disgraceful, so there is no meanness in a Muslim, but rather the meanness is the meanness of ignorance."¹⁶ He answered him with the strong and clear logic of pure Islam.

History has recorded many stories and evidence about the Imam's behavior towards slaves, including:

A-A freed slave of Ali bin Al-Hussein (PBUH) used to take care of building, an estate for him. Nonetheless, he was corrupted and wasted a lot on it. Imam was angry and distressed because of what he saw. So the Imam knocked him with a whip that was in his hand, but he regretted it. When he went home, he went to the slave, and found him naked and the whip in his hands. He thought he wanted to punish him. So his fear increased. However, Ali bin Al-Hussein (PBUH) took the whip and extended his hand to it, and said: "knock me by the whip and take revenge from me." The slave said: "O Lord, by God, I deserve punishment, how could I take revenge from you?! The Imam said: "You have to take revenge." Slave said: I forgive you. He repeated that to



him over and over again. When he refused to take revenge, the Imam said "since you refused, the estate is a charity for you."¹⁷

B-A maid of Ali bin Al-Hussein (PBUH) pours water on him while he was performing poured for prayer. So the ewer fell from the hand of the maid on his face, slashing his head. The girl said: God Almighty says: [And those who repress anger]. He answered: I have suppressed my anger. She said: [And those who pardon people]. He answered her: God has forgiven you. She said: [And God loves the doers of good.] He (PBUH) answered: Go, you are free.(Al-Imran, 134).¹⁸

C-Ali bin Al-Hussein called his slaves twice, but he did not answer him. Yet, he answered him the third time. Imam asked him: Son, did you hear my voice? He said: Yes, I did. The Imam asked him, "why didn't you answer me?" The slave answered: "I feel safe with you." He replied: "Praise be to God who made my servants secure me."¹⁹

D-Moreover, it was narrated that he had guests, and he asked a slave of him to cook a roast in the oven. So, the slave approached him quickly, and the sword fell from him onto the head of the sons of Ali bin Al-Hussein (PBUH), hitting his head and killing him. While the slave was afraid and confused, Ali bin Al-Hussein said: "You are free, because you did not choose that." Then, he took his son's dead body and buried him. It is a level that expresses sublime transcendence and great morality, which has been a story for generations.²⁰

These stories indicate the tolerance of Ali bin Al Hussein (PBUH) and his kind treatment, forgiveness, benevolence and humanity, for which we find no equal or counterpart except with his grandfathers. He took upon himself the notion of the emancipation of slaves. He used to hold an annual forum for their

emancipation. Also, he aims to encourage others to emancipate in order to achieve human freedom, and get rid of slavery. The Imam (PBUH) used to acquire many slaves to live with him for a period of time, then he would release them to live free. "Every year, on the last night of the blessed month Ramadan, the Imam used to free his slaves..." He was doing all this for the sake of The Almighty God.²¹



Conclusion

Imam Ali bin Al-Hussein is a leading abolitionist and a guideline for anti-slavery movements in communities facing injustices, and demanding legislation, and equality. Not surprisingly, he symbolizes the revitalization of the true Islamic spirit. Through his policy toward slaves, he traces the Islamic traditional views as documentations of human dignity. The wisdom of the pure religious teaching, represented by Imam Ali bin Al-Hussein, is sourced from the Creator. Through his highly humane dealings with slaves, he changes their lives, integrates them into Muslim societies, and wins their love, hearts and minds. He emphasizes the values of Islam in his view of human equality. He educates Muslims and urges them to end this unfair phenomenon by encouraging them to buy slaves and free them. His policy adds a supplementary force to the strength of pure Islamic thoughts. Generally, the school of Ahl al-Bayt aims to liberate man from all kinds of enslavement, and seeks to build a free and generous man who owes no submission except to his Creator.

Notes

- 1 Allama Majlisi, Bihar al-Anwar, Vol. XXXVI, 1403 AH, p. 360.
- 2 Jacobin, Jacobi history, Vol. III: Dar Sader - Beirut – Lebanon, p. 303.
- 3 Sheikh Ali al-Kurani: Jewels of History 1426 AH, p. 92.
- 4 Abu Naim Ahmed bin Abdullah Al-Asbhani, The Ornament of The Saints and The Layers of The Pure, Al Saada Press - next to Egypt Governorate, 1394 HA, p.136.
- 5 Muhammad Baqir al-Sadr, The Imams of Ahl al-Bayt (peace be upon them) and Their Role in Fortifying the Islamic Message, 1432 AH, p. 337.
- 6 Sayyid Jaafar Mortada al-Amili, Al Sahih in al-Sirah, Vol.II, p. 146.
- 7 Muhammad bin Yazid al-Mubarrad, The Book of Condolences, Elegies and Commandments, p. 139.
- 8 Al-Bahaa, Complete in History, Vol. II, p. 260.
- 9 Sheikh Al-Kulayni, Al-Kafi, Vol.VIII, p. 268.
- 10 Freamon, Bernard K. 1998. "Slavery, Freedom, and the Doctrine of Consensus in Islamic Jurisprudence," Harvard Human Rights Journal 11 (Spring 1998): 1–64.
- 11 Abdullah Dibba, "How Islam Abolished Slavery, Leaving No Loopholes," 10th (June 2020).
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